

largest private flying school trains its own instructors and signs a five-year bond with them at Rs 2 lakh per month. However, such initiatives are rare. Foreign flight training schools are rushing in to fill the training gap. An estimated 4,000 aspiring Indian pilots are learning to fly at schools in the Philippines and the US where it takes just six months to notch up 200 flying hours and costs between Rs 14 lakh and Rs 20 lakh. In 2007, about 70 per cent of licences issued by DGCA were on the basis of foreign licences acquired by applicants.

G. Krishnamurthy, who manages the Gurgaon-based Suparsa Aviation Services which represents four flying schools in the US, Philippines and Canada, says he has screened and sent

the criteria for getting a licence. Abroad, airlines recruit cadets with no flying experience and then send them to flight training schools at their expense. In India, flying training is mostly self-funded. Much of the DGCA-approved training syllabi dished out by flying schools in the country is outdated and suited only for small four-seater aircraft. "There is an urgent need to expand and re-orient training curriculum with simulators, cockpit management systems and flight training instruments to make for genuine pilot training," says Captain Yashraj Tongia, chief flying instructor at Yash Air.

The issue of lack of a clear vision on **HIGH FLYERS: Students at the Bombay Flying Club**

has received 37 proposals for flying institutes across the country. Punjab will soon offer infrastructure at the Amritsar, Ludhiana and Patiala clubs through public-private partnerships. "As flying schools have become profitable, private investment will help institutes take off sooner," says Viswajit Khanna, secretary, civil aviation, Punjab.

Flying clubs, meanwhile, have asked DGCA to make it mandatory for fresh CPL holders to compulsorily act as instructors for a fixed period before taking up commercial assignments. "That way, they would gain credible flying experience before moving on to commercial pilot duties and temporarily fulfil the requirement of instructors," says Captain Manoj Chhabria of

FLIGHT PLAN

- Set up more modern flight training institutes equipped with modern aircraft, instructors and simulators.
- Modify syllabi to include commercial aircraft flying. Emphasise on instrument flying and multi-engined aircraft.
- Recruit more flying instructors by increasing pay packets.
- Set up a national aviation university to deal exclusively with flying training.
- Airlines to recruit cadets directly and send them for training, to reverse the current trend.



MANJAR DEODHAR

90 candidates abroad, 50 of whom have returned to join as co-pilots with private airlines.

Aviation analysts, however, warn that the rush to amass flying hours could end up injecting inadequately trained pilots into the system. "Trainees may not be able to absorb flying skills so quickly," warns former DGCA H.S. Khola.

Many trainees return from the Philippines with a CPL showing that they have logged 200 flying hours in about six months. It is well known that trainees cannot usually log more than three hours a day without getting fatigued. Industry watchers call for a need to reverse the trend of financial ability and not intellectual ability being

training was raised last year by the M.K. Kaw Committee set up by MOCA in 2005. The Committee called for a comprehensive national training policy along with mandatory standards of teaching and assisting the institutes in improving their infrastructure. It also called for a national aviation university under the ministry with the existing training clubs functioning as affiliated institutions. This apex body for aviation training, research and management would not only set the standards but also facilitate collaboration with international institutions. Little progress, however, has been made on these proposals.

In the short term, the Government is setting up more flying schools. DGCA

Madhya Pradesh Flying Club Limited.

The ministry is planning to increase capacity at IGRUA to produce 200 pilots every year. The Airports Authority of India and the Canadian Aviation Electronics recently signed an MOU to set up a National Flying Training Institute in Gondia district of Maharashtra, Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel's hometown. When operational in two years, it will train 200 pilots annually. Unless a slew of measures are taken, the Indian aviation miracle faces the unhappy prospect of having both imported aircraft as well as pilots.

with Amarnath K. Menon, Ramesh Vinayak, Amitabh Srivastava, Rohit Parihar, Jhimil Motihar and Ambresh Mishra